

Acupuncture Channels & Points I

AC300 / AC375 · VUIM Summer 2026 · Dr. Vivian Zhang, Ph.D.

reMarkable Edition

WEEK

7

Week 7 Study Guide

The Eight Extraordinary Vessels – Qi Jing Ba Mai

GV (28 pts) + CV (24 pts) + Chong, Dai, Yang/Yin Qiao, Yang/Yin Wei (share primary-meridian points)

This Week Covers:

- Governor Vessel (GV/Du Mai) and Conception Vessel (CV/Ren Mai) – the only two vessels with their own dedicated points
- Thoroughfare Vessel (Chong Mai) – sea of the 12 meridians, sea of blood, sea of the zang-fu organs
- Belt Vessel (Dai Mai) – the only vessel running horizontally around the waist
- Yang Qiao Mai + Yin Qiao Mai – the Heel vessel pair (limb movement, sleep/wake balance)
- Yang Wei Mai + Yin Wei Mai – the Link vessel pair (exterior/interior yin-yang regulation)
- “One source, three branches” – how Du, Ren, and Chong all arise from the lower abdomen
- The Eight Confluent (Master-Couple) Points – all 4 opening-point pairings
- Two coalescent-point-count discrepancies flagged for Dr. Zhang (Yang Qiao, Yang Wei)

QUIZ 5 (this week) covers: the Eight Extraordinary Vessels + cumulative Middle Circuit review.

CAM p.82-89, 275-293 | MOA p.17-25, 493-497, 527-533 (per written syllabus, Week 7; page ranges verified against physical CAM/MOA)

Slides: Dr. Vivian Zhang, Lecture_7vivian11_12.pdf (76 slides)

Structural Overview: What Makes a Vessel “Extraordinary”

The Defining Trait

None of the Eight Extraordinary Vessels pertains to a zang or fu organ, and none has an interior–exterior paired relationship the way the 12 primary meridians do. Only Du Mai (GV) and Ren Mai (CV) have their own dedicated acupuncture points -- the other six vessels borrow points from the primary meridians they cross (their “coalescent points,” Jiao Hui Xue).

“One Source, Three Branches” (Yi Yuan San Qi)

Du Mai, Ren Mai, and Chong Mai all arise from inside the lower abdomen and emerge together at the perineum before diverging into three separate pathways -- Du posteriorly along the spine, Ren anteriorly along the abdomen/chest, Chong internally along the spine with a superficial branch beside the Kidney meridian. Chinese: Yi Yuan San Qi -- “one source, three branches.”

Du Mai (posterior spine) <- Perineum / Lower Abdomen -> Ren Mai (anterior midline)

□

Chong Mai (internal + beside Kidney meridian)

“Sea” Titles at a Glance

- **Du Mai (GV)** *Sea of the yang meridians*
- **Ren Mai (CV)** *Sea of the yin meridians*
- **Chong Mai** *Sea of the 12 meridians · Sea of blood · Sea of the zang-fu organs*

Only Two Vessels Have Their Own Points

GV (28 points) and CV (24 points) are the only Extraordinary Vessels with dedicated acupuncture points of their own. The other six -- Chong, Dai, Yang Qiao, Yin Qiao, Yang Wei, and Yin Wei -- share points with the primary meridians they cross. Those shared points are called coalescent points (Jiao Hui Xue), distinct from the confluent (opening) points used to clinically access each vessel.

The Eight Confluent Points (Ba Mai Jiao Hui Xue)

Confluent points are special acupuncture points -- one per vessel, always located on a primary meridian -- that connect each Extraordinary Vessel to the 12 regular meridians and are the clinical “opening” points used to access that vessel. The 8 confluent points pair up into 4 “master-couple” combinations, each used together to treat a shared symptom picture.

Chong Mai + Yin Wei Mai

SP 4 Gongsun × PC 6 Neiguan

Stomach, heart, chest -- Gongsun opens Chong, Neiguan opens Yin Wei; combine to treat chest/epigastric/cardiac patterns.

Du Mai + Yang Qiao Mai

SI 3 Houxi × BL 62 Shenmai

Inner canthus, neck, ear, shoulder -- spinal stiffness/pain, febrile disease, mental disorders.

Ren Mai + Yin Qiao Mai

LU 7 Lieque × KI 6 Zhaohai

Lung, throat, chest, diaphragm -- cough, sore throat, chest tightness.

Dai Mai + Yang Wei Mai

GB 41 Zulinqi × SJ 5 Waiguan

Outer canthus, ear, cheek, neck, shoulder -- lateral-body pain, febrile disease, exterior patterns.

Governor Vessel (Du Mai)

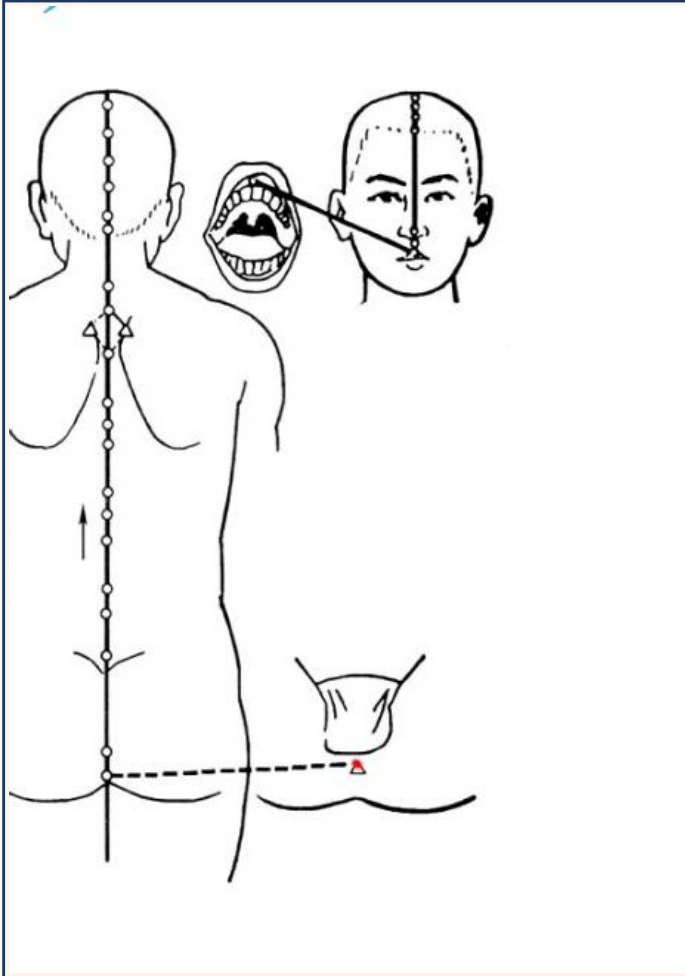
Sea of the Yang Meridians

Points: 28

Coalescent pts: 2

Confluent pt: SI 3 Houxi

Running Course



Lecture Fig. — Governor Vessel
Lecture_7vivian11_12.pdf, slide 17 (Dr. Zhang)

Course Summary

- Arises from the lower abdomen, emerges at the perineum (near CV 1 Huiyin)
- Runs posteriorly along the interior of the spinal column (GV 1 Changqiang → BL 12 Fengmen)
- Reaches the nape (GV 16 Fengfu), enters the brain
- Ascends to the vertex (GV 20 Baihui)
- Winds along the forehead to the columella of the nose, ends at GV 28 Yinjiao

First & Last Points

First: GV 1 Changqiang -- midway between the tip of the coccyx and the anus (prone position)

Last: GV 28 Yinjiao -- at the junction of the frenulum under the top lip and the gum

Locating the Confluent Point

SI 3 Houxi: Ulnar side of the hand, just behind the head of the 5th metacarpal bone, at the junction of the palm and dorsal skin.

Coalescent Points (Jiao Hui Xue)

BL 12 Fengmen · CV 1 Huiyin

Confluent (Opening) Point

SI 3 Houxi

Pairs with BL 62 Shenmai (Yang Qiao Mai)

Physiological Functions

- Sea of the yang meridians -- governs the qi of all yang meridians
- Guides and stimulates the body's yang qi; keeps the body warm
- Confluent point Houxi (SI 3) treats spinal pain/heaviness and relieves fever

Pathological Symptoms

- Stiffness and pain along the spinal column
- Heavy sensation in the head
- Vertigo and shaking
- Mental disorders
- Fever

Clinical Pearl / Memory Aid

GV runs the length of the spine and ends at the nose -- think "spine to face, yang runs the race." Its confluent point Houxi (SI 3) sits on the SAME side of the hand as the vessel's posterior course, which is why it treats spinal stiffness so directly.

Conception Vessel (Ren Mai)

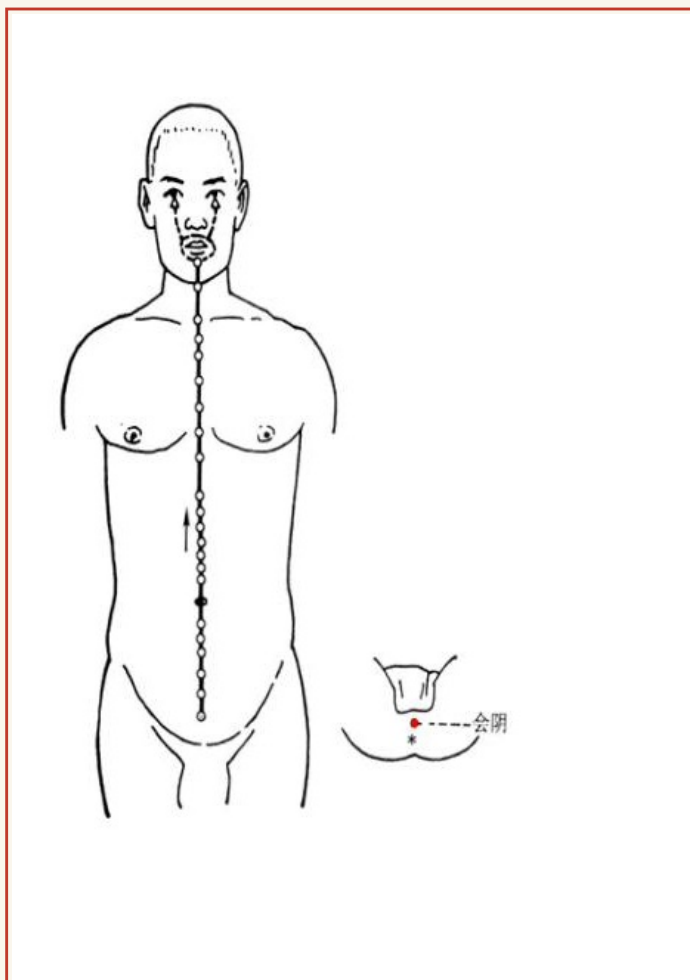
Sea of the Yin Meridians

Points: 24

Coalescent pts: 2

Confluent pt: LU 7 Lieque

Running Course



Lecture Fig. – Conception Vessel
Lecture_7vivian11_12.pdf, slide 25 (Dr. Zhang)

Course Summary

- Arises from inside the lower abdomen, emerges at the perineum (CV 1 Huiyin)
- Runs anteriorly to the pubic region, ascends along the interior of the abdomen (through CV 4 Guanyuan)
- Continues along the front midline of abdomen and chest, reaches the throat
- Curves around the lips (meets GV 28 Yinjiao)
- Passes through the cheek, enters the infraorbital region, ends at ST 1 Chengqi

First & Last Points

First: CV 1 Huiyin -- between the anus and root of scrotum (M) / posterior labial commissure (F)

Last: CV 24 Chengjiang -- in the depression at the center of the chin

Locating the Confluent Point

LU 7 Lieque: Radial (thumb) side of the forearm, about 1.5 cun above the transverse wrist crease.

Coalescent Points (Jiao Hui Xue)

ST 1 Chengqi · GV 28 Yinjiao

Confluent (Opening) Point

LU 7 Lieque

Pairs with KI 6 Zhaohai (Yin Qiao Mai)

Physiological Functions

- Sea of the yin meridians -- receives and bears the qi of all yin meridians
- CV 4 Guanyuan is a major Xi/tonification point ("the source point in the lower abdomen")
- Confluent point Lieque (LU 7) is also the Luo-Connecting point of the Lung meridian

Pathological Symptoms

- Pathology of the yin channels (esp. Liver + Kidney)
- Infertility
- Disorders of the urogenital system
- Irregular menstruation
- Abdominal pain

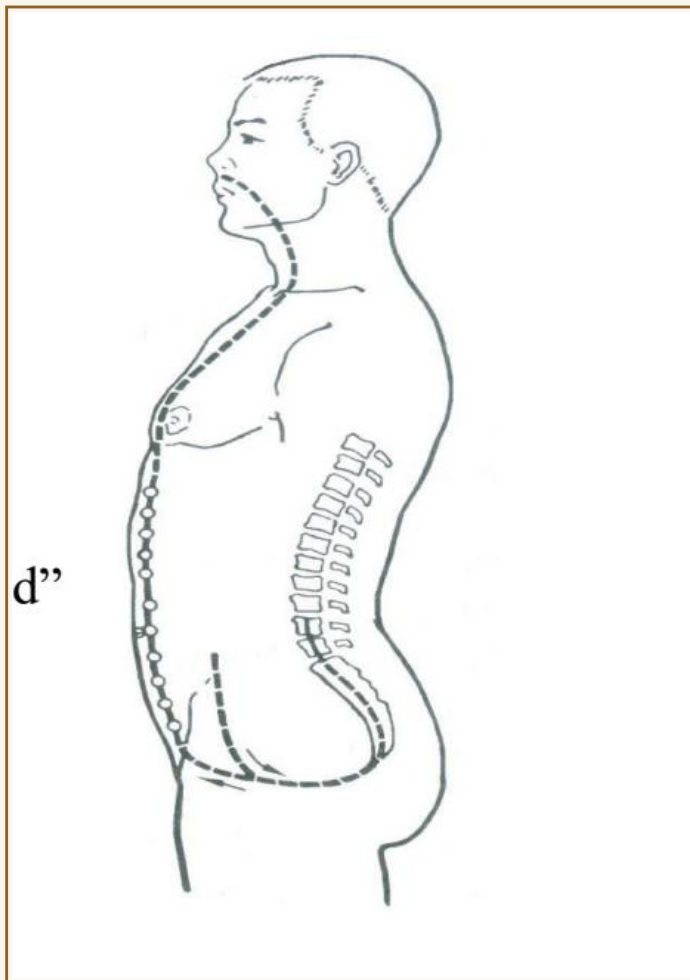
Clinical Pearl / Memory Aid

CV is GV's mirror image: anterior midline instead of posterior, sea of YIN instead of yang. Its confluent point Lieque (LU 7) doubles as the Lung Luo-Connecting point -- one point, two jobs, which is why it's so often chosen for throat/chest complaints tied to yin-channel patterns.

Thoroughfare Vessel (Chong Mai) Sea of the 12 Meridians · Sea of Blood · Sea of the Zang-Fu Organs

Points: **shares w/ primary meridians**Coalescent pts: **14**Confluent pt: **SP 4 Gongsun**

Running Course



Lecture Fig. — Thoroughfare Vessel
Lecture_7vivian11_12.pdf, slide 34 (Dr. Zhang)

Course Summary

- Arises from inside the lower abdomen, emerges at the perineum (CV 1 Huiyin)
- Ascends inside the spinal column
- Superficial branch passes through ST 30 Qichong, communicates with the Kidney meridian
- Runs along both sides of the abdomen (beside KI 11-KI 21) up to the throat
- Curves around the lips

Locating the Confluent Point

SP 4 Gongsun: Medial side of the foot, in front of and below the base of the 1st metatarsal bone.

Coalescent Points (Jiao Hui Xue)

CV 1 · CV 7 · ST 30 · KI 11 · KI 12 · KI 13 · KI 14 · KI 15 · KI 16 · KI 17 · KI 18 · KI 19 · KI 20 · KI 21

Confluent (Opening) Point

SP 4 Gongsun

Pairs with PC 6 Neiguan (Yin Wei Mai)

Physiological Functions

- Sea of the 12 meridians; sea of the zang-fu organs; sea of blood
- Runs parallel to the Kidney meridian -- shares 11 Kidney-meridian points as coalescent points
- Confluent point Gongsun (SP 4) is also the Luo-Connecting point of the Spleen meridian

Pathological Symptoms

- Gynecological disorders
- Male urological disease / male infertility
- Abdominal pain

Clinical Pearl / Memory Aid

Chong shares its very first station (CV1 Huiyin) with GV and CV -- "one source, three branches" -- then runs the length of the trunk right beside the Kidney meridian. Three "sea" titles (12 meridians / blood / zang-fu organs) makes it the single most powerful of the 8 vessels for constitutional/gynecological work.

Belt Vessel (Dai Mai)

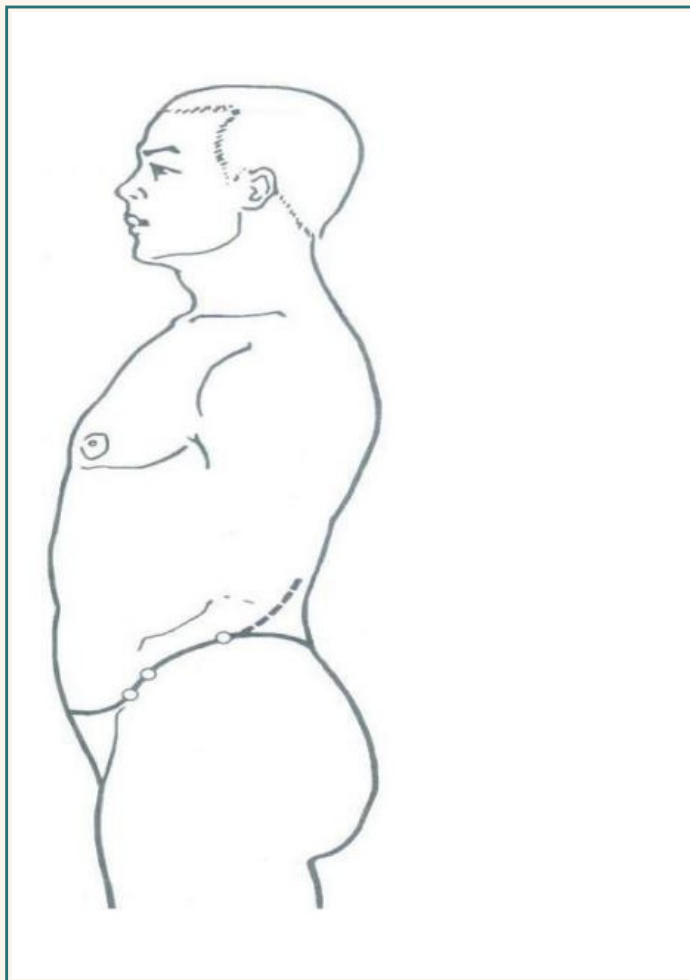
The Binding/Girdling Vessel (not a “sea”)

Points: **shares w/ primary meridians**

Coalescent pts: **3**

Confluent pt: **GB 41 Zulinqi**

Running Course



Lecture Fig. – Belt Vessel

Lecture_7vivian11_12.pdf, slide 41 (Dr. Zhang)

Course Summary

- Originates below the hypochondriac region (GB 26 Daimai)
- Wraps horizontally around the waist (GB 27 Wushu, GB 28 Weidao)
- The ONLY one of the 8 vessels that runs horizontally rather than vertically

Locating the Confluent Point

GB 41 Zulinqi: Dorsum of the foot, near the proximal end of the 4th toe.

Coalescent Points (Jiao Hui Xue)

GB 26 Daimai · GB 27 Wushu · GB 28 Weidao

Confluent (Opening) Point

GB 41 Zulinqi

Pairs with SJ 5 Waiguan (Yang Wei Mai)

Physiological Functions

- Controls/binds all the longitudinally-running meridians -- “the belt that holds them together”
- Closely related to Du, Ren, and Chong Meridians
- Structurally unique: horizontal, not vertical -- no true “sea” title in the lecture

Pathological Symptoms

- Fullness in the abdomen
- Irregular menstruation
- Pain in the lumbar region

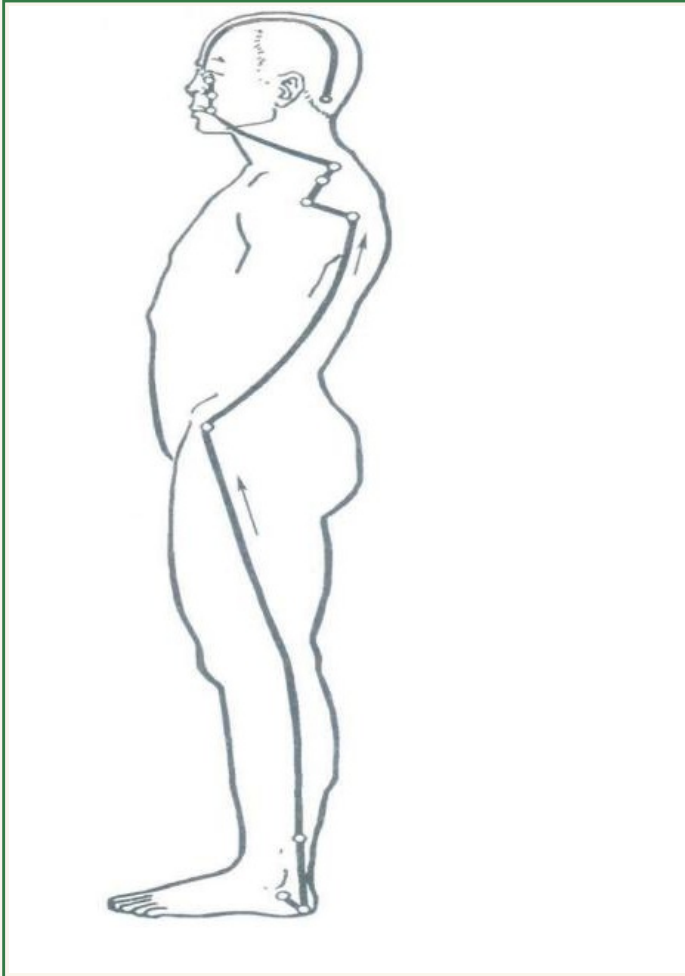
Clinical Pearl / Memory Aid

Dai is the odd one out geometrically -- picture a literal belt cinched around the waist at GB 26/27/28, binding every vertical vessel and meridian that passes through it. No course to trace top-to-bottom, just a horizontal loop -- which is exactly why “waist pain with no clear up/down direction” points here.

Yang Heel Vessel (Yang Qiao Mai)

Points: **shares w/ primary meridians**Coalescent pts: **10**Confluent pt: **BL 62 Shenmai**

Running Course



Lecture Fig. — Yang Heel Vessel
Lecture_7vivian11_12.pdf, slide 47 (Dr. Zhang)

Course Summary

- Starts on the lateral aspect of the heel (BL 62 Shenmai, BL 61)
- Ascends along the posterior border of the fibula (BL 59), external malleolus
- Lateral thigh (GB 29), posterior hypochondrium, posterior axillary fold
- Shoulder (SI 10, LI 15, LI 16), neck, corner of the mouth (ST 4), inner canthus (SI 1, BL 1)
- Forehead, ends by merging into the Gallbladder meridian (GB 20 Fengchi)

Locating the Confluent Point

BL 62 Shenmai: Directly below the external malleolus, in a depression between BL 60 and BL 62's landmark bony structures.

Coalescent Points (Jiao Hui Xue)

BL 1 · BL 59 · BL 61 · BL 62 · GB 20 · GB 29 · SI 10 · ST 1 · ST 3 · ST 4

Slide header states "(12)" coalescent points but only 10 are named -- flagged for Dr. Zhang.

Confluent (Opening) Point

BL 62 Shenmai

Pairs with SI 3 Houxi (Du Mai)

Physiological Functions

- Balances movement of the extremities together with Yin Qiao (they meet at the inner canthus)
- Governs wakefulness / activity -- keeps the body alert and active

Pathological Symptoms

- Diseases of the eyes
- Tightness/spasm of lateral lower-leg muscles (seizures, paralysis)
- Pain and stiffness in the lumbar region

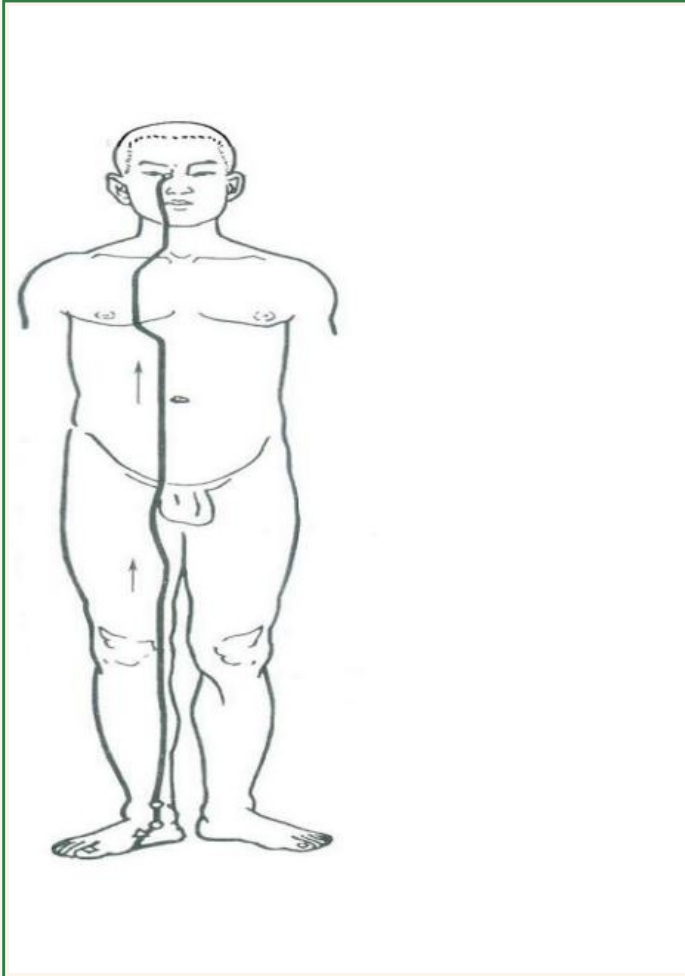
Clinical Pearl / Memory Aid

Yang Qiao = LATERAL heel to LATERAL/posterior head, ending by merging into GB. Pairs with Du Mai (both "yang") via Houxi + Shenmai. Remember the function split with its Yin partner: Yang Qiao keeps you UP and moving; Yin Qiao brings you DOWN to rest.

Yin Heel Vessel (Yin Qiao Mai)

Points: **shares w/ primary meridians**Coalescent pts: **3**Confluent pt: **KI 6 Zhaohai**

Running Course



Lecture Fig. — Yin Heel Vessel
Lecture_7vivian11_12.pdf, slide 53 (Dr. Zhang)

Course Summary

- Starts at the posterior aspect of the navicular bone (KI 6 Zhaohai)
- Ascends via the upper medial malleolus, posterior medial leg/thigh (KI 8)
- External genitalia, abdomen and chest, supraclavicular fossa
- Adam's apple (in front of ST 9 Renying), zygoma
- Ends at the inner canthus (BL 1), meeting the Bladder meridian and Yang Qiao Mai

Locating the Confluent Point

KI 6 Zhaohai: Directly below the medial malleolus, in the depression at the posterior aspect of the navicular bone (this IS the confluent point -- KI 6 is also the vessel's starting point).

Coalescent Points (Jiao Hui Xue)

KI 6 · KI 8 · BL 1

Confluent (Opening) Point

KI 6 Zhaohai

Pairs with LU 7 Lieque (Ren Mai)

Physiological Functions

- Balances movement of the extremities together with Yang Qiao (meet at inner canthus)
- Governs calm / rest -- promotes relaxation and restful sleep (opposite of Yang Qiao)

Pathological Symptoms

- Diseases of the eyes
- Tightness/spasm of medial lower-leg muscles (seizures, paralysis)
- Lower abdominal pain

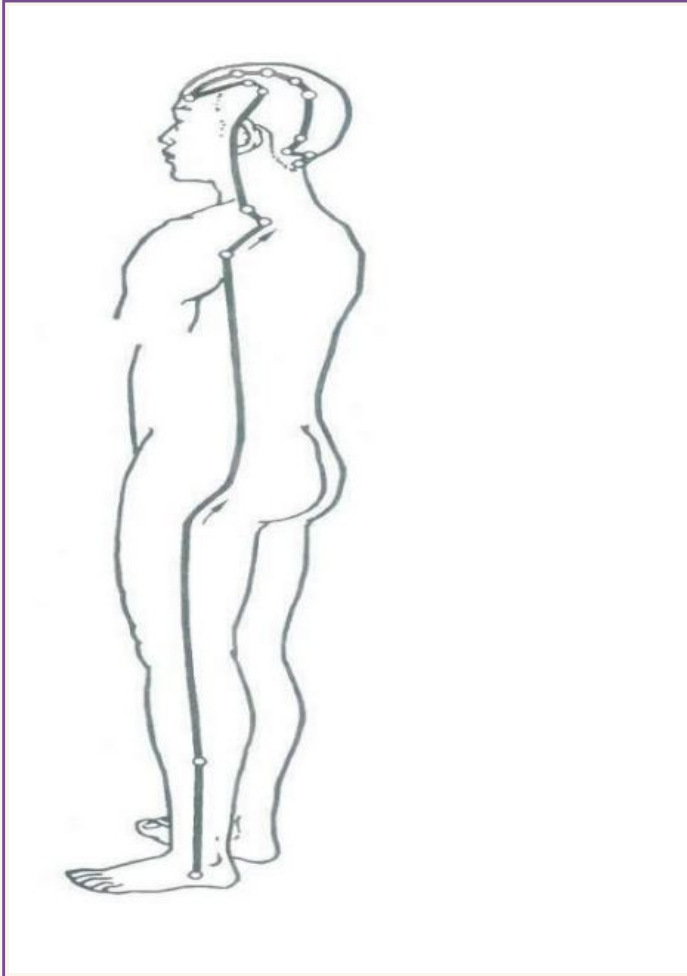
Clinical Pearl / Memory Aid

Yin Qiao = MEDIAL heel to the inner canthus, merging into Bladder/Yang Qiao at the eye. The two Heel vessels literally meet at the inner canthus -- that shared meeting point is why both show up on "eye disease" pathology lists. Yin Qiao's job: calm, rest, sleep.

Yang Link Vessel (Yang Wei Mai)

Points: **shares w/ primary meridians**Coalescent pts: **14**Confluent pt: **SJ 5 Waiguan**

Running Course



Lecture Fig. — Yang Link Vessel
Lecture_7vivian11_12.pdf, slide 60 (Dr. Zhang)

Course Summary

- Originates at the lateral side of the heel (BL 63 Jinmen)
- Ascends via the external malleolus, lateral leg (GB 35), hip region
- Posterior hypochondriac/costal region, posterior axilla, shoulder (SI 10, SJ 15, GB 21)
- Retroauricular region, forehead (GB 13, GB 14), back of neck (GB 15-20)
- Ends by meeting the Du Meridian (GV 15, GV 16)

Locating the Confluent Point

SJ 5 Waiguan: Back of the forearm, two finger-widths above the wrist crease, between the radius and ulna.

Coalescent Points (Jiao Hui Xue)

BL 63 · SI 10 · GV 15 · GV 16 · GB 21 · GB 35 · GB 13 · GB 14 · GB 15 · GB 16 · GB 17 · GB 18 · GB 19 · GB 20

Slide header states "(15)" coalescent points but only 14 are named -- flagged for Dr. Zhang.

Confluent (Opening) Point

SJ 5 Waiguan

Pairs with GB 41 Zulinqi (Dai Mai)

Physiological Functions

- Connects to all yang meridians, especially the Du Meridian
- Dominates the exterior of the whole body
- Joint function with Yin Wei: regulates qi flow between the yin and yang meridians

Pathological Symptoms

- Chills and fever, vertigo
- Muscular fatigue, stiffness, and pain
- Pain and distension in the waist

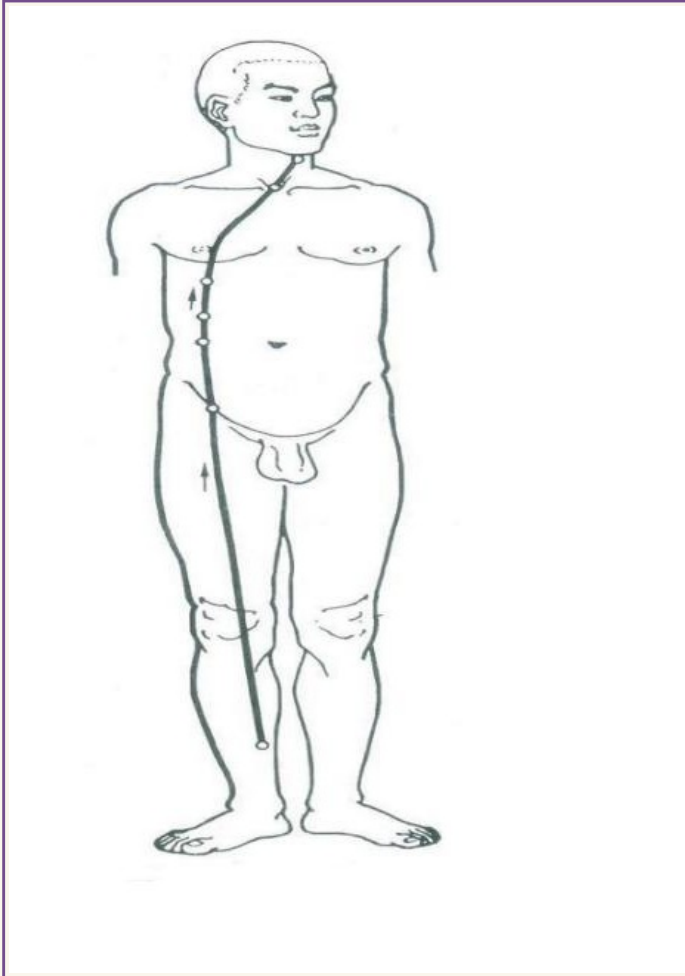
Clinical Pearl / Memory Aid

Yang Wei runs UP the lateral body from the heel, gathers nearly the whole GB channel along the head (GB13-20) before merging into Du Mai -- "dominates the exterior." Waiguan (SJ 5) pairs with Zulinqi (GB 41, Dai Mai) -- both vessels patrol the lateral/exterior body, which is why the pairing treats lateral-body and febrile-exterior patterns.

Yin Link Vessel (Yin Wei Mai)

Points: **shares w/ primary meridians**Coalescent pts: **7**Confluent pt: **PC 6 Neiguan**

Running Course



Lecture Fig. — Yin Link Vessel
Lecture_7vivian11_12.pdf, slide 67 (Dr. Zhang)

Course Summary

- Starts at the medial aspect of the leg (KI 9 Zhubin)
- Ascends via the medial leg and thigh, abdomen
- Spleen meridian (SP 13, SP 15, SP 16), chest (LR 14)
- Neck, meets the CV Meridian (CV 22, CV 23)

Locating the Confluent Point

PC 6 Neiguan: Two finger-widths above the wrist crease, on the inner (palmar) forearm, between the two tendons.

Coalescent Points (Jiao Hui Xue)

KI 9 · SP 13 · SP 15 · SP 16 · LR 14 · CV 22 · CV 23

Confluent (Opening) Point

PC 6 Neiguan

Pairs with SP 4 Gongsun (Chong Mai)

Physiological Functions

- Connects to all yin meridians, especially the Ren Meridian
- Dominates the interior of the whole body
- Joint function with Yang Wei: regulates qi flow and maintains yin-yang equilibrium

Pathological Symptoms

- Chest pain
- Waist pain
- Hard lumps in the upper abdomen

Clinical Pearl / Memory Aid

Yin Wei runs UP the medial body from KI 9, crosses SP and LR points on its way to the chest, then merges into Ren Mai at the neck -- "dominates the interior." Neiguan (PC 6) pairs with Gongsun (SP 4, Chong Mai) -- the single most-used confluent pairing in clinic for chest, stomach, and heart complaints (deep-breathing + bilateral pressure, per Dr. Zhang's demonstration).